

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Pride Sunday

The Many Faces of God

31 May 2026



Photographer Unknown

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on SLANE and ABBOT'S LEIGH

Meditation on *Ave Maris Stella* (Gregorian Chant)

Somewhere Over The Rainbow (Harold Arlen & Yip Harburg, adapted by C. Bull)

Camas High School Select Vocal Ensemble, Ethan Chessin, Director

Geistliches Lied, Op. 30 (Johannes Brahms)

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Ave Maris Stella (Mark Thomas)

Rise Stronger (J. Neumann & T. Hudson)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

Words of Gathering

Ayur Barduev and Dr. Matthew White

Listen! Listen! The Divine names us all:
Holy, Beloved, Cherished, Valued!

In the image of God, we were created and called good.
In abundant diversity, God's likeness is found.
We believe God delights in us and all creation!

Holy One, may we be those who recognize and proclaim
your beauty and goodness in unexpected places and people.
Surprise us, challenge us, transform us!

Reveal to us the sacredness of every life,
of our unique ways of being,
of every physical manifestation of your Spirit,
as we reject all messages that belittle or degrade any among us.

God calls each of us:
out of the places we hide,
out of insecurities,
out of shame,
out from under that which silences love and justice.
Come out, people of God! God calls us to courage!

-adapt. from M. Jade Kaiser

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

All the Colors of the Rainbow

ABBOT'S LEIGH

All the colors of the rainbow live unseen in daily light,
But their splendors find expression when released to human sight;
So the church reveals most beauty where diversity is real:
Breadth of race and class and gender, room for doubt and space to heal.

All the body's parts are wanted, nor can one despise the rest:
Head and hand must work together, as must eye and ear and chest;
So the church needs all its members for a range of ministries:
Varied gifts with one great mission, "Do this for the least of these."

Every language gains more music when the words for peace appear:
Pax, Salaam, Eirini, Heiwa, Pace, Santi, Frieden, Mir.
Though our tongues make sounds that vary all bespeak a common home:
Longing for the end of conflict and a new life in God's Shalom.

Teach us, God, our need of others; through them help us fully live.
Wean us from our selfish habits; let us listen, learn, forgive.
May we see your longed-for image in each human heart and face,
And behold how those around us can be channels of your grace.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

God of wild love and extravagant acceptance,
Spirit of boldness and beauty,
You are faithfully present in both the grit and glitter of life,
and you are present here with us now.

Awaken us to your dream for creation:
*A world in which every member of the human family is free
to flourish however you have made them.*

Forgive us for the moments we have held back
your ever-flowing current of love, dignity, and justice.
*Remake us into a people eager to see you
in the faces, bodies, and expressions of all people.*

Remind each of us to emerge from the shadows of our lives
and shine fearlessly and courageously.
*Ignite the Divine Light within us to sparkle through the prism
of our bodies and brighten every corner of this Earth.*

Holy One, You call each of us beloved.
*Each of us cherished.
Each of us desired.*

*Each of us sacred.
And so, we give you thanks, now and forever.*

-adapt. from Rev. Sam Lundquist

*May it be so.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!*

***Introit**

"Step By Step"

ANNIE LENNOX

Lorenzo Zapata, *Soloist*, combined choirs, Dr. David Harris, *Conductor*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sonnie Swenston

*Holy Being,
whom we call by many different names,
Blessed are you,
Blessed are we in you.
May we create with you
a realm of mercy, peace, and justice.
May love be done in the here and now,
as it is in the infinite.
May we share life in bread and hope.
For our failure to love, we need forgiveness.
May we find the paths of reconciliation.
In the midst of evil's incarnation,
from the powers that have power over our spirits
and our structures, may we find liberation.
In the power that is love,
we seek to live and move and have our being.
May it be so,
now and forever.
Amen and Amen.*

[nancylsteeves]

***Gloria Deo**

*Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.*

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Fregin

*In the beauty of this day and in the light of the rainbow
that shines over this gathered community,
let us remember that our God is always and forever
with us, and for us!*

*May the Peace and Love of God be with you all.
And also with you!*

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Children's Conversation

Rev. Chad Tanaka Pack

Following this conversation, children are invited to join us for our Sunday morning programming. If you were unable to check in your children prior to the service, please accompany them to our Children's Area and check them in before returning to the service. Children must be picked up after worship before you head to the Pride Festival in the Forecourt.

Reading from the Wisdom of Our Tradition *from Genesis, chapter 1*

Sonnie Swenston

For these words of wisdom from our ancestors,
Thanks be to God!

Musical Gift

"Colors Of The Wind" ALAN MENKEN & STEPHEN SCHWARTZ
Christin Byrdsong, *Soloist*, Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

Prayers with the People

Rev. Fregin

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

A strong rainbow pours itself out,
bending the eastern sky with glory,
it brings with it a powerful beauty
to soothe my needy heart with hope.

And I do believe I hear the sun
wild with wonder and rejoicing,
laughing at the once-darkened sky
now parted in colored splendor.

I remember then the One who came,
who broke our stormy night apart,
and shook despairing hearts with hope;
this One told truth of things beyond
and gave us more than gold.

This rainbow filling late-June sky
touches more than just the earth;
it makes its mark within my depth
and lets my heart look up in hope.
-Joyce Rupp

Silence

Musical Gift

"Nancy"
Rev. Michael Lehman, *Marimba*

EMMANUEL SÉJOURNÉ

Prayer of Our Hearts

Wondrous God, lover of lion and lizard,
cedar and cactus, raindrop and river,
we give thanks for the splendor of this, your world!
We thank you that woven in the tapestry of earth
are the varied threads of incredible diversity.

Created in Your image, we are of many colors and cultures, ages
and classes, sexualities and gender identities.
Different and alike, we are your beloved people.
Free us, we pray, from fears of difference
that divide and wound us.

Move us to dismantle our attitudes and systems of prejudice.
Renew our commitment to make this a community for all people –
that all who encounter and share life here
may know the grace and challenge of faith.
In our life together, grant us minds and hearts eager to learn,
reluctant to judge, and responsive to the leading of Your loving Spirit.
-adapt. Rev. Ann B. Day

We pray all of this may be so.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

“When the Earth Stands Still”

DON MACDONALD

Laude and Camas High School Select Vocal Ensemble, Ethan Chessin, *Conductor*

Sermon

The Many Faces of God

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Generosity

Ayur Barduev

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

“Ev’ry Time I Feel The Spirit”

WILLIAM DAWSON

Combined Choirs, Dr. Ernest H. Harrison, *Conductor*, John Musselman, *Soloist*

“Somewhere Over The Rainbow” HAROLD ARLEN AND YIP HARBURG
Molly Pease, *Soloist* and Dr. Christoph Bull, *Piano*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator’s praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Offering Prayer**

Dr. Matthew White

Holy God, we are your people, created in your image.
In our diversity we have strength;
in our shared humanity a common hope,
a vision of life unbound by time.

We have come together to celebrate,
to reflect, and to recommit ourselves to your work.

Shake us out of our complacency,
rock our comfortable certainties
and challenge us to recognize the face of the Christ
in the eyes of everyone we meet.

May our hearts be open to the challenge
of your call to true freedom,
our minds and hands ready
to grasp the opportunity for change.

*Inspire us with your message,
open us to the joy of your word,
and guide us as we prepare
to answer your call to open our doors
even wider in this place, we call home.*

May it be so, O God.
May it be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen.

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

As we leave this place,
let us remember and exclaim who we are...

*We are the people who heal each other,
who grow strong together,
who know what it means
to live in community,
moving towards a common dream
for a world filled with inclusiveness,
compassion, and generosity,
found in the power of the love of God,
the company of the Christ,
and the leading of the Holy Spirit.*

Go now in peace,
as those who walk a common way,
and may you find others
to walk on this path with you.
May the hospitality you share
return to you through the love of God
both this day, and forevermore.

*May it be so both now,
all in all the days to come!*

Choral Response

"Tshotsholoza" SOUTH AFRICAN WORK SONG, arr. JEFFREY L. AMES
Combined Choirs, Markus Ruddy, *Soloist*, Dr. Fahad Siadat, *Conductor*

*Hymn for the Journey

God of Many Faces

SLANE

God of many faces, we offer our praise,
Singing your glory through all of our days.
Hear ever growing voices, once fragile, now strong,
Carrying melodies in expansive new songs.

God of many genders, our world reflects you,
Sunrise and sunset uniting our hues,
woven into a city with jewels of all shades,
Houses of ruby and walls rowed with jade.

God of many names, we invite you to show
Us the new names that reflect our true souls.
Breathe with your holy spirit to give us the Word
That will indwell dry bones, grating new life once heard.

God of many bodies, abide within ours,
Shifting more each day through time and through scars.
Come sanctify our bodies, all fashioned by you,
Holier every day, still becoming more true.

-Lyrics by Amy Cerniglia

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*
Fuga in C (Alessandro Scarlatti)

Inside The Music

Dr. David Harris

"I am moved every year that we celebrate PRIDE. The addition of Dr. Harrison and GMCLA to our service brings energy and presence. This year we're also joined by the combined choirs of Camas High School from Portland to help us fill the chancel with sound. PRIDE celebrations are one of those festivities that feel essential to me. They are a chance to recognize how our culture has been positively impacted and grown decisively because of the LGBTQI+ communities. We also have the chance to reflect on the burdens that so many have gone through for the sake of that change, and how many continue to suffer. We have a long way to go, and we've come so far. The music today reflects a wide range of hope-filled offerings. Much like the sermon title, we're a many-faced musical expression today. Each of the pieces remind us in their own way that perseverance and joy in the face of hardship carry power. A special thanks to everyone who helped to make today happen, and to this community for continuing to prioritize this annual celebration."